

Psalms 126

The Lord Hath Done Great Things

The Lord hath done great things for us; whereof we are glad

KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *When the LORD turned again the captivity of Zion, we were like them that dream.*
- 2 *Then was our mouth filled with laughter, and our tongue with singing: then said they among the heathen, The LORD hath done great things for them.*
- 3 *The LORD hath done great things for us; whereof we are glad.*
- 4 *Turn again our captivity, O LORD, as the streams in the south.*
- 5 *They that sow in tears shall reap in joy.*
- 6 *He that goeth forth and weepeth, bearing precious seed, shall doubtless come again with rejoicing, bringing his sheaves with him.*

2 · CONTEXT

Psalm 126 likely reflects the return from Babylonian exile, remembered as an event so unexpectedly joyful that it felt like a dream even to those who lived through it, prompting recognition even among surrounding nations that the Lord had acted decisively. From that remembered joy, the psalm turns to present, unfinished need, praying for a further 'turning' of fortune and framing present hardship as seed sown in tears that will yet yield a joyful harvest. Henry treats the shift from past deliverance to present petition as instructive: remembered joy fuels renewed hope rather than replacing the need for continued prayer.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-3

The psalm opens in remembered wonder: when the Lord turned again the captivity of Zion, it felt like a dream, laughter and singing filling mouths that had long been silent. Even the surrounding nations recognized what had happened, saying the Lord had done great things for them—an external witness confirming the scale of the deliverance—matched by the psalmist's own glad agreement.

Verse 4-6

Attention shifts to present, ongoing need: turn again our captivity, as the dry streams of the southern desert are turned into flowing water again. Sowing in tears is promised a harvest of joy; the one who goes out weeping, carrying seed, will return rejoicing, bringing in the sheaves—present hardship reframed as productive rather than wasted.

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

A specific, remembered deliverance so significant it once felt like a dream does not exempt anyone from continuing to pray for further restoration; past joy and present, unresolved need coexist honestly in the same short psalm. Sowing amid tears is not treated as contradicting hope but as the very activity that produces the joyful harvest still to come.

Application for life today.

Recall a past deliverance so significant it still feels almost dreamlike, and let that remembered joy fuel a present request rather than making you feel you should no longer need to ask for anything. If you are currently 'sowing in tears'—investing effort or faithfulness amid real grief—let verses 5–6 reframe that labor as seed with a future harvest, not evidence that your effort is wasted. Notice how even outsiders recognized God's work in verse 2; consider whether your own testimony of past deliverance could similarly point others toward Him.

5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. What past deliverance in your life still feels almost dreamlike (vv. 1–2), and how can remembering it fuel a present request rather than making you feel you shouldn't need to ask further?

2. Where are you currently 'sowing in tears'—investing faithful effort amid real grief—and how does the promise of a joyful harvest (vv. 5–6) reshape how you view that labor?

3. How might your own testimony of what God has done, like the surrounding nations' recognition in verse 2, point someone else toward Him?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, *Commentary on the Whole Bible* (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).